



took place in 1991, but it is now one of the most popular international sports events. Over 750 million people worldwide watched the 2015 tournament on television.

Eyes on the money

One of the greatest gender disparities in sport is financial: male athletes are paid more than women. In the US, the first legal challenge to this was the Women's Educational Equity Act of 1974, better known as Title IX. The law meant that schools and universities had to offer women equal access to athletics scholarships. In 1973, Billie Jean King played a televised tennis match against male former champion Bobby Riggs, dubbed the "Battle of the Sexes". King's victory over Riggs (viewed by 90 million people) was a major milestone for public acceptance of female excellence in sport.

Today, while more sports offer equal prize money, some still lag behind. Male golfers in the US Open take home almost twice as much as the female champion, and in World Cup cricket, the male team can make up to seven times more than the female team. Such pay gaps are often linked to media rights, with claims that men's sports draw bigger audiences, and therefore generate more profit.

▲ Snow adventures

Austrian snowboarding star Anna Gasser competes at the 2014 Olympic Winter Games. Prior to taking up competitive snowboarding, Gasser was a member of the Austrian National Gymnastics Team.

PROFILES

SPORTING HEROINES

Ann Glanville (1796-1880) achieved fame as a British gig rower. Part of a female crew of four rowers who took part in local regattas, Glanville was congratulated by Queen Victoria at Fleetwood when she watched the team beat an all-male crew. In 1842, the team went to an event at Le Havre but the French refused to put up a team against the women. Instead, they raced against an all-male crew from the paddle steamer that transported them - and won.

Alice Milliat (1884-1957) was a teacher, swimmer, rower, and hockey player, who demanded that the Olympic Games open more of their events to women. After they refused, she founded the International Women's Sports Federation in 1921. The body organized four Women's World Games, international competitions modelled on the Olympics, with the first taking place in Paris in 1922.

Babe Zaharias (1911-56) first competed in US women's basketball, before turning to athletics. She qualified for the 1932 Los Angeles Olympics, where she won gold medals in the 80 m hurdles and javelin, and a silver in the high jump. Zaharias excelled at other sports, particularly golf, winning the US Women's Open three times.

Angela James (b.1964) began competing in the Central Ontario Women's Ice Hockey League, playing for Seneca College from 1982 to 1985. In 1990, she led Canada to victory in the first women's world ice hockey championship, repeating the feat in 1992, 1994, and 1997. She carried on playing until 2000, and in 2010 was one of the first two women elected to the Hockey Hall of Fame.

Steffi Graf (b.1969) made her professional tennis debut in her native Germany aged 13. In 1986, she won the first of 107 career tournament victories, and the next year she won the first of 22 major singles championships. She dominated women's tennis, and in 1988 became the only person to ever achieve the "Golden Slam" (winning all four major tournaments and Olympic gold in a calendar year).

Caster Semenya (b.1991) is a leading middle distance runner from South Africa. In 2009, she won gold in the 800m at the Berlin World Championships, but her hyperandrogenism (high testosterone levels) led to controversy; she was made to undergo testing to verify her sex. She temporarily withdrew from competition but returned to win gold at the 2012 and 2016 Olympics.